

Christopher Tastad

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Senior bioinformatics leader with 5+ years managing technical teams and driving organizational transformation across academic and consortium environments. Proven track record of scaling operations from startup to enterprise level, delivering \$250K+ in vendor cost savings, and offering leadership to 650+ global collaborators across international research efforts. Expert in building high-performance teams, establishing data governance frameworks, and translating complex technical initiatives into strategic business outcomes.

LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Senior Manager, Bioinformatics

Oct 2023 – Present

Icahn School of Medicine at Mount Sinai, Cho Lab

New York, NY

- Lead 5-person bioinformatics team driving technical strategy for cutting-edge genomic analysis across 10+ concurrent multi-year projects, establishing collaborative frameworks where none previously existed.
- Designed comprehensive personnel management systems spanning quarterly workload assessments, recruitment and screening of technical personnel, and knowledge transfer protocols for personnel transitions, fundamentally improving project delivery and organizational continuity.
- Established rigorous project management standards implementing per-project repository management, version control adoption, and documentation frameworks, transforming publication packaging quality and efficiency from ad-hoc to systematic solutions.
- Implemented enterprise Sourcegraph deployment and served as admin for secure team LLM access, pioneering integration of AI-assisted development tools in bioinformatics workflows and establishing institutional standards for responsible AI adoption in genomic analysis.
- Introduced *light* Agile methods including daily stand-ups, weekly office hours, and data round table meetings, fostering systematic collaboration across on-site and remote staff in previously siloed environment.
- Led institution-first Xenium spatial analyzer device deployment including custom configuration, full security review, and system implementation, establishing institutional deployment standards for emerging platforms.
- Selected as 10x Genomics beta partner for cloud hosting feature development, directly influencing product roadmap through strategic feedback and validation of enterprise capabilities.

Lead Data Engineer

Feb 2021 – Present

NIDDK IBD Genetics Consortium

New York, NY

- Direct data governance across 650+ global collaborators spanning dozens of international consortia and partner institutions, ensuring HIPAA compliance and streamlined data sharing protocols for multi-site genomic studies.
- Lead consortium data team of 4 bioinformaticians and data scientists, directing technical strategy, coordinating collaborative analysis efforts, and establishing standardized methodological approaches for consortium-wide studies.
- Replaced \$250K+ annual vendor contracts with cost-effective open-source solutions, meeting and exceeding data processing requirements while demonstrating strategic resource optimization at consortium scale.
- Led comprehensive Google Workspace transition for inter-institutional collaboration, serving as super-admin for 200+ user base while establishing policy management and communication frameworks enabling systematic international coordination.
- Designed comprehensive brand strategy for IBDGC including graphic redesign, web services architecture, international partnership platforms, and consortium visibility initiatives, fundamentally improving global research coordination capabilities.
- Established cross-institutional methods working groups facilitating knowledge transfer and standardization across partner sites, creating systematic collaboration frameworks for international research coordination.

Bioinformatician II

Feb 2021 – Oct 2023

Icahn School of Medicine at Mount Sinai, Cho Lab

New York, NY

- Contributed to \$9.5M+ grant awards through technical leadership, experimental design, and strategic vision, providing data management expertise across all consortium projects and influencing methodological approaches at international scale.
- Sourced, built, and deployed purpose-built \$60k+ on-prem supplementary compute infrastructure, expanding team computational capacity 3x at fraction of commercial alternatives through strategic vendor negotiations and technical planning.
- Established organizational knowledge management implementing Atlassian services (Confluence/Jira) across team and consortium with rigorous information organization standards, transforming institutional memory and project tracking capabilities.
- Developed official Mount Sinai institutional execution profile for nf-core pipelines, creating standardized HPC configuration endorsed by core scientific computing team and accepted as open-source contribution to nf-core community codebase.
- Established strategic resource accessibility initiative deploying enterprise-grade platforms specifically to overcome substantial resource barriers, enabling scalable growth of imaging and spatial transcriptomics workflows.

Supervisor

Oct 2017 – Oct 2018

UPS, Small Sort Operations

Minneapolis, MN

- Managed a team of 35 direct reports in largest operational unit in the Northern Plains District HQ hub, overseeing daily operations and performance optimization.
- Delivered an immediate 15% production increase to area within first month (representing 40% of daily volume) through process improvements and team development initiatives.
- Developed novel improvement projects leading to elimination of package missorts and enhanced training programs with disability access accommodations.

Load Planning Engineer

Oct 2018 – Jan 2021

UPS, Industrial Engineering

Minneapolis, MN

- Primary authority in guiding all load functions for 112 outbound doors, mediating hub, feeder, and engineering priorities across complex operational environment.
- Advanced district level interests through industrial engineering technologies for operational, flow, and system analysis, contributing to regional efficiency improvements.
- Generated daily cost savings through identification and elimination of inefficient trailer runs averaging \$500-1000 value per optimization.

TECHNICAL EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant

May 2019 – Feb 2021

University of Minnesota Dept. of OBGYN, Starr Lab

Minneapolis, MN

- Executed full rewrite of cancer gene web application, deploying new ETL framework and reducing technical debt while improving system performance.
- Applied bioinformatic analysis to copy number variation on largest single-cell sequencing human cancer dataset of its kind.

Graduate Research Assistant

Jan 2016 – Aug 2017

National Marrow Donor Program, Bioinformatics

Minneapolis, MN

- Served as investigator in corporate R&D department focusing on hematological cancers, contributing to IP generation initiatives using 13 million patient database.
- Developed clinical and basic research approaches in cell therapy, immunology, and organ transplant genetics.

Research Associate

Dec 2007 – Jan 2013

The Stem Cell Institute, Asakura Lab

Minneapolis, MN

- Performed basic science research in skeletal muscle development, receiving 4 co-authorships and contributing to successful R01 grant applications.
- Authored significant writing efforts for group manuscripts and major grant awards, demonstrating scientific communication and strategic planning capabilities.

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

Led 650+ global collaborators across international genomics consortium
Delivered \$250K+ annual cost savings through strategic vendor optimization
Contributed to \$9.5M+ in successful grant awards through technical leadership
Established data governance frameworks for 0.5PB+ genomic datasets
Selected as industry beta partner for emerging genomics platform development
Pioneered enterprise AI integration deployment and secure LLM access for bioinformatics team workflows
Developed official institutional nf-core nextflow execution profile accepted as open-source contribution

CORE COMPETENCIES

Leadership & Management: Team leadership, Strategic planning, Personnel development, Cross-institutional collaboration, Project management, Agile methodologies, Change management

Business Operations: Budget management, Vendor negotiations, Cost optimization, Grant writing, Regulatory compliance, Risk management, Process improvement

Technical Strategy: Data governance, Infrastructure architecture, Platform development, Technology evaluation, Digital transformation, Enterprise systems

Genomics & Data Science: Bioinformatics, Statistical analysis, Machine learning, Cloud computing (AWS), Database management, Workflow automation

EDUCATION

University of Minnesota

Minneapolis, MN

Master of Science in Bioinformatics and Computational Biology

2021

University of Minnesota

Minneapolis, MN

Bachelor of Science in Biochemistry, College of Biological Sciences

2012